

Ultrabooks



Ultrabooks are the latest fad among laptops. Agent001 gives you the skinny on these lean, mean machines

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If you have been following the category of laptops closely in the past six months, then the word 'ultrabook' wouldn't have been lost on your ears. Yes, after the breakthrough era of netbooks back in 2007 till now, ultrabooks is a new sub-category within mainstream laptops that's exploding all around us. As far as 2012 goes, it is the new buzzword of the PC market. Here's what you should know if you or your friends are contemplating to buy a new laptop soon.

What is an Ultrabook?

Intel defined netbooks very clearly back in 2007-2008 as mini-laptops with a small, compact form factor, ranging from screen size 10 to 11.6-inch all running some variant of

Intel's Atom processor. However, ultrabooks aren't categorized in such well-defined terms. Having reviewed four of the seven available ultrabooks in India, we know that these are mainly thin and light laptops that offer increased ultraportability without compromising on performance. Other specific design and hardware attributes of an ultrabook range from the MacBook Air-like unibody chassis with a sealed battery compartment – for prolonged battery life; a low-powered variant of the latest Intel Core i3/i5/i7 processors with onboard graphics; and SSDs for storage, among other things.

How is it any different from a regular laptop I hear you ask? Well, for the most part, it isn't. Compared to the netbook, which brought the 10-inch form factor to the masses and made it mainstream, ultrabooks aren't hugely different from laptops sold now or 5 years ago. In fact, they're a natural progression of a category's evolution and demands – slimmer design, better performance, longer battery life. But it's all packaged in a different marketing machine called the 'ultrabook.'

While there may be small differences between a regular laptop and an ultrabook's design and hardware, the biggest difference I see is that from the manufacturers. Earlier, offering an ultraportable laptop for consumers was considered as

essential to complete a range or portfolio of distinct laptops for a few well-established laptop manufacturers. But now, that isn't the case any more. Nearly every laptop manufacturer, including the ones who never before sold an ultraportable laptop, will launch an ultrabook this year – most of them are set to launch multiple variants.

Why is that? It's high on Intel's agenda this year. In fact, according to Intel 70% of new laptops launched this year will be ultrabooks. Acer, Asus, Dell, HP, Lenovo, Samsung, and Toshiba have already launched their first ultrabook in India – Acer was the first among the lot, while Dell joined the club only last month. Most of them have a 13-inch form factor and a slim, ultraportable profile. I think the heaviest ultrabook I've picked up weighed 1.5 kg, while the lightest was around 1.3 kg – that's the same weight as a 10-inch netbook!

We must say that we're quite impressed by the overall capability of most ultrabooks we tested, running on Intel's Core i5 or Core i7 processor, they could easily match and, in some cases, surpass the performance offered by a 15-inch entertainment laptop. The HP Folio 13, especially, didn't let its faster processor dampen its battery life score – it lasted easily over 5 hours on a single charge – a feat that most regular laptops will find hard or impossible to emulate. So yes, the excitement surrounding ultrabooks is justified to a large extent.

Should you buy one?

For the time being, ultrabooks are selling at a premium. Since they are so few in number, manufacturers are trying to extract higher profit margins, pricing them between ₹50,000 to ₹1,00,000. In fact, Acer's Aspire S3 and Samsung's recently launched ultrabook remain two of the most inexpensive ultrabook in the market.

Don't forget Intel wants to offer consumers a low-priced ultraportable laptop which doesn't compromise on performance, and it has promised that 70% of all laptops launched this year will be ultrabooks. If you wait a little longer, not only prices will fall, but you'll have an ultrabook based on Intel's upcoming Ivy Bridge platform in the second half of 2012. **d**



The Asus Zenbook is one anorexic laptop